



Step-by-Step guide: Data-cleaning features in spreadsheets

This reading outlines the steps the instructor performs in the next video, [Data-cleaning features in spreadsheets](#). In the video, the instructor explains how to use menu options in spreadsheets to fix errors.

Keep this step-by-step guide open as you watch the video. It can serve as a helpful reference if you need additional context or clarification while following the video steps. This is not a graded activity, but you can complete these steps to practice the skills demonstrated in the video.

What you'll need

If you'd like to follow along with the examples in this video, choose a spreadsheet tool. Google Sheets or Excel are recommended.

To access the spreadsheet the instructor uses in this video, click the link to the template to create a copy of the dataset. If you don't have a Google account, download the data directly from the attachments below.

Link to logistics data: [International Logistics Association Memberships - Data for Cleaning](#)

Link to cosmetics data: [Cosmetics Inc. - Data for Cleaning](#)

OR

Example 1: Use conditional formatting to highlight blank cells

Conditional formatting is a spreadsheet tool that changes how cells appear when values meet specific conditions.

1. Open the spreadsheet [International Logistics Association Memberships - Data for Cleaning](#).
2. Select the range of cells to which you'll apply conditional formatting. In this example, you'll select columns A through L, except for columns F and H. To select all columns except for F and H:
 - a. Select cell A to highlight column A.
 - b. Hold down the SHIFT key and at the same time use your mouse to select cell E. This will highlight all the columns between A and E.
 - c. To select the remainder of the columns, hold down the CONTROL (Windows) or COMMAND (Mac) key while you select cells G, I, J, K, and L.
 - d. Columns A through L in your spreadsheet should be highlighted except Column F and Column H.
3. From the menu, select Format, then Conditional formatting. The columns you've selected should turn a light shade of green, and a new Conditional format rules tool will appear. Additionally, the Apply to range field should indicate the cells you've selected.
4. Next, apply a condition to these cells to change the cell color if the cell is empty. In the Format cells if drop-down, select Cell is empty.

5. Select the Formatting style field. Select a bright color from the drop-down to make the blank cells stand out.
6. Select Done.

Example 2: Remove duplicates

Remove duplicates is a spreadsheet tool that automatically searches for and eliminates duplicate entries from a spreadsheet. This is faster and easier than searching the data by scrolling through it.

1. Create a copy of your dataset by right clicking the Association ABC membership tab and selecting Duplicate. This is a good practice, as it protects against accidentally deleting important data. Continue working in the new sheet, Copy of Association ABC memberships.
2. In the menu, select Data, then Data cleanup, then Remove duplicates.
3. Check the box next to Data has header row.
4. Check the box next to Select All to inspect the entire spreadsheet.
5. Select Remove duplicates.

Example 3: Format dates consistently

Format dates to make all of the data in your spreadsheet consistent. This makes items easier to find and manipulate.

1. Select column J (Membership valid through), which contains dates.
2. From the menu, select Format, then Number, then Date.

Example 4: Use split to separate data into columns

The split menu option is helpful when you have more than one piece of data in a cell and you want to separate those pieces of data into different cells.

1. Select column L (Certification).

2. In the menu, select Data, then Split text to columns.
3. The delimiter (for example, a comma) will be automatically detected.
4. If needed, specify the separator manually in the dropdown that appears in your spreadsheet.

Example 5: Use split to fix numbers stored as text

SPLIT is a spreadsheet function that divides text around a specified character and puts each fragment into a new, separate cell.

1. Open the spreadsheet [Cosmetics Inc. - Data for Cleaning](#).
2. Notice that cell F12 contains an error.
3. Select column E (Orders).
4. In the menu select Data, then select Split text to columns.
5. This removes the quotation marks from cell E12 so the spreadsheet recognizes the data in the cell as a number. This resolves the error in cell F12.

Key Concepts:

- **Split Function:** A function that divides text in a cell into multiple cells based on a specified delimiter, useful for managing complex data entries.
- **Conditional Formatting:** A spreadsheet tool that changes the appearance of cells based on specific conditions, such as highlighting blank cells.
- **Data Formatting:** The process of ensuring consistency in data presentation, such as formatting dates to a standard format.
- **Remove Duplicates:** A feature that automatically identifies and eliminates duplicate entries in a dataset, streamlining data management.